Three Role Models Analyzed

Ndiaye Dia, Wedji Kane, and Yoshua Bengio: three paths in artificial intelligence

This document presents three profiles of people whose paths can serve as a source of inspiration. For each person, it retraces the major stages, then analyzes the qualities, values, and levers for action that emerge from their story. A comparative analysis and several reflection questions conclude the dossier.

Why these three profiles?

Ndiaye Dia and Wedji Kane are two Senegalese AI practitioners and co-founders of the Institute of Algorithms of Senegal. Yoshua Bengio is a world-renowned scientist in deep learning. Together, they show three complementary ways of creating impact: building local institutions, connecting talent with markets, and guiding global research.

Profile 1: Ndiaye Dia

The builder of African digital institutions

Category	Information
Field	Artificial intelligence, algorithms, knowledge entrepreneurship
Origin	Keur Matar Daro, Thies region, Senegal
Education	Bachelor’s degree in mathematics and computer science, Cheikh Anta Diop University (2017); Ecole Polytechnique in Paris, with a Senegalese government excellence scholarship; training in AI
Key achievements	Founder of the Institute of Algorithms of Senegal (December 2020); initiator of SALTIS (2021); co-founder and director of Jangat.ai (generative AI)
Recognition	Guest at the ECOSOC Youth Forum of the United Nations (April 2024); selected for "Leading the Future 2030" (2024)

Background

The eldest of a family focused on education, Ndiaye Dia was drawn very early to logic and problem-solving, which led him to mathematics and then algorithms. After Cheikh Anta Diop University, he joined Ecole Polytechnique in Paris, specializing in digital sciences and AI, and then worked on models applied to text analysis in major technology companies. During the pandemic, he collaborated remotely with researchers from the Virtual University of Senegal on modeling the spread of COVID-19.

He then chose to build locally: the Institute of Algorithms of Senegal, a learning center designed to democratize digital knowledge; the SALTIS forum for "demystifying science" and awakening vocations; and the Jangat.ai startup. According to Sika Finance (June 2026), he also heads the Data and AI department of the organizing committee for the 2026 Dakar Youth Olympic Games.

Obstacle overcome

Two interruptions to his education were related to civil-status problems. He explains that this series of obstacles strengthened his determination rather than holding him back.

Analysis

" **Qualities:** perseverance, long-term vision, clarity of expression, humility; several colleagues emphasize his generosity and ability to bring people together.

" **Values:** digital sovereignty, accessibility of knowledge, grounding in African realities, and rejection of elitist models.

" **Lever of impact:** creating structures - an institute, a forum, and a startup - that equip other people rather than succeeding alone.

" **What is inspiring:** an administrative obstacle does not prevent an outstanding path, and it is possible to return to one’s home country and build there.

Profile 2: Wedji Kane

The data engineer who connects local talent with global markets

Category	Information
Field	Data engineering, AI, digital health, technology entrepreneurship
Origin	Senegal; career developed in France
Education	S1 baccalaureate with an excellence scholarship; telecommunications engineering degree, ENSEIRB-MATMECA Bordeaux (2021); AI engineering degree, Mines Paris - PSL (2022)
Positions	Data engineer at Onepoint (2022-2025), then Carrefour France; co-founder of the Institute of Algorithms of Senegal; co-founder and managing director of LinkSenAI (founded in 2025); general coordinator of SALTIS 2025

Background

A profile published in 2022 described her as the first in her S1 examination center to earn the baccalaureate, with an excellence scholarship and a second national prize in mathematics. She continued at an engineering school in France, worked as a data engineer, and became involved in digital health in Senegal while co-founding the Institute of Algorithms of Senegal.

In 2025, she founded LinkSenAI, which recruits tech and data talent based in Senegal for international digital projects, particularly in Europe. In the same year, she coordinated SALTIS (November 25 and 26, 2025, Museum of Black Civilizations in Dakar), an event that the press presented as a major gathering for AI in French-speaking Africa.

Message she carries

At the launch of SALTIS 2025, she called on Senegal to master AI and make it useful, inclusive, and accessible. She also stressed the alliance between a young team and the experience of those who opened the way.

Analysis

" **Qualities:** consistent academic excellence, ability to coordinate varied stakeholders - institutions, startups, and researchers - and organizational skills.

" **Values:** technological sovereignty, inclusion, intergenerational transmission, and AI serving concrete needs such as health.

" **Lever of impact:** building a bridge between local skills and international demand, while showcasing talent without forcing it to leave.

" **What is inspiring:** experience gained abroad can become a resource for one’s country of origin, and a woman can lead both a technology company and a major scientific event.

Profile 3: Yoshua Bengio

The scientific pioneer who became a voice for caution

Category	Information
Field	Deep learning, artificial intelligence, AI safety
Origin	Born March 5, 1964, in Paris; Canadian citizen
Education	Bachelor’s, master’s, and doctoral degrees at McGill University
Positions	Full professor at the University of Montreal; founder and scientific advisor of Mila; co-founder of Element AI; co-chair and scientific director of the International AI Safety Report
Distinctions	2018 Turing Award, with Geoffrey Hinton and Yann LeCun; 2017 Marie-Victorin Prize; 2019 Killam Prize; Fellow of the Royal Society of London; Officer of the Order of Canada; Knight of the Legion of Honour

Background

Yoshua Bengio is one of the three researchers who received the 2018 Turing Award for foundational work on deep learning; they are sometimes called the "godfathers of AI." He is presented as the world’s most cited computer scientist. He co-authored the reference book Deep Learning (MIT Press, 2016) and founded Mila, the Quebec AI institute.

More recently, he redirected his work toward AI safety. He chairs the International AI Safety Report, published in January 2025 and then in June 2026, and in June 2025 launched LawZero, a nonprofit organization aiming to design AI systems that are both high-performing and safe by design.

Analysis

" **Qualities:** scientific rigor, exceptional productivity, ability to build research communities, and intellectual courage.

" **Values:** responsibility as a researcher, caution regarding risks, international cooperation, and science serving the common good.

" **Lever of impact:** fundamental research, institution building - Mila and LawZero - and influence on public decision-makers.

" **What is inspiring:** a scientist at the top of their field can change direction to address the consequences of what they helped create.

Comparative analysis

What distinguishes them and what brings them together

Criterion	Ndiaye Dia	Wedji Kane	Yoshua Bengio
Area of impact	Education and AI ecosystem in Senegal	Tech talent, data, and digital health	Global research and AI safety
Main lever	Create institutions (IAS, SALTIS, startup)	Connect local talent with markets; coordinate a flagship event	Fundamental science; institutions (Mila, LawZero); public expertise
Territorial grounding	Strong: Senegal is at the center of his commitments	Dual: France and Senegal	International: Canada, UN, OECD, EU
Relationship to AI	A tool for sovereignty and access to knowledge	A useful, inclusive, human tool	Powerful technology that must be made safe
Education	UCAD, then Ecole Polytechnique	Engineering schools in Bordeaux and Paris	McGill (bachelor's, master's, doctorate)
Documented obstacle	Two interruptions to schooling (civil status)	Not specified in the sources	Not specified in the sources

Common points

" **Academic excellence as a starting point:** each relies on demanding scientific training, but none is limited to individual competence.

" **The move from competence to institution:** institute, forum, startup, laboratory, or nonprofit organization. Their impact comes from what they build for others.

" **A responsible vision of AI:** useful, inclusive, and human for Dia and Kane; safe for Bengio. None presents AI as an end in itself.

" **Transmission:** training people, awakening vocations, bringing generations together, or structuring a research community.

Notable differences

" **Scale:** local and continental for Dia and Kane, global for Bengio.

" **Generation and career stage:** Dia and Kane are building their institutions; Bengio is redirecting a career already distinguished by the Turing Award.

" **Relationship to country of origin:** Dia and Kane act explicitly for Senegal, whereas Bengio acts as an international scientific voice.

Sources

" *Le Soleil*, "Ndiaya Dia: the discreet architect of a digital Africa," July 22, 2025 - lesoleil.sn/actualites/technologie/ndiaya-dia-larchitecte-discret-dune-afrique-numerique/

" Sika Finance, "Senegal: these young people pushing boundaries... through artificial intelligence," June 19, 2026 - sikafinance.com

" Osiris.sn, "Wedji Kane, a data engineer fully devoted to the cause of digital health in Senegal," October 16, 2022 - osiris.sn

" We Are Tech Africa, "Wedji Kane connects Senegal’s tech talent with global companies," March 30, 2026 - wearetech.africa

" AllAfrica / *Le Soleil*, "SALTIS 2025: general coordinator Wedji Kane for future-oriented technological sovereignty," November 26, 2025 - fr.allafrica.com

" LawZero, Yoshua Bengio’s page - lawzero.org/en/team/yoshua-bengio

" Official Yoshua Bengio website - yoshuabengio.org

" International AI Safety Report, contributors page - internationalaisafetyreport.org

" Wikipedia, "Yoshua Bengio" - en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Yoshua_Bengio